

AN EARTHLY PARADISE.

A Stranger's View of Santa Barbara, and her Surroundings.

(Correspondence of the Clinton Mass., Courier.)

SANTA BARBARA, Cal., Jan. 1881.

At Point Conception the coast of California makes a sudden turn from a southerly to an easterly direction, and runs east and west for fifty miles. About midway on this coast facing toward the south and entirely surrounded by mountains lies Santa Barbara. The cold winds have no chance to get at this little valley, protected as it is by the Santa Inez range, which rises 4,000 feet above the sea. The normal southerly direction of the coast line is continued from Point Conception to below Los Angeles by high and mountainous islands, on one of which, San Nicholas, an Indian woman spent eighteen years alone. The story of this woman's solitary confinement was given in full in *Scribner's* for September last. These islands form a barrier against all storms and soften the asperity of all winds blowing from the sea. There we see that nature has done all in her power to make the climate perfect.

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The mean winter temperature is 58° F. and the difference between the Winter and the Summer is only 15° ; then it is never cold in the Winter or hot in the Summer. It is very seldom that a frost is experienced, and therefore the flowers bloom the year through. Formerly nearly all the houses were made of adobe, but since the Americans have come, neat little cottages and elegant dwellings have sprung up, and fine business blocks have been built. A great many of the old adobes still exist, however, and add a picturesque appearance to the town. They are built of sun-dried bricks and retain their muddy color; the roofs are covered with tiles. Imagine a red earthenware drain-tile cut in halves longitudinally, making a semi-cylinder; these are placed in rows on their convex surfaces, lapping over like shingles; then to cover the cracks between two tiles, a third is placed over them on its concave face. The whole makes a heavy and not very protective, but yet a very picturesque covering.

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The main business thoroughfare is State street, and extends back two miles, directly from the steamboat wharf. The smaller streets branch off to the right and left like lesser arteries.

THE ARLINGTON

is the principal hotel, and is unequalled south of San Francisco. The grounds are filled with choice varieties of semi-tropical plants and deer captured in the mountains. Nearly every little cottage has its pretty garden patch, and the people seem to vie with each other in keeping their grounds neat and in-

viting. In many of these gardens can be seen from seventy-five to ninety varieties of roses, geranium hedges, heliotrope, and fuchsias trained over the piazzas and full of blossoms, calla lilies four feet high and almost as common as weeds. The streets are shaded by the peculiar eucalyptus and the pepper tree. The eucalyptus or blue gum is a native of Australia, and grows straight and spindling to an immense height. The pepper has all of the grace of the willow, and is in addition an evergreen which in the Winter is covered with long panicles of bright red berries. In this country these trees grow so fast that in five years they will shade a house. In short, the whole town is one continuous garden.

On Thanksgiving day one of the local preachers delivered a sermon in which he showed that his congregation had cause to be profoundly thankful for their good fortune in having such a place as Santa Barbara to live in, discoursing to some length on the different advantages of the same. Then, thinking he had dwelt long enough on earthly matters, he proceeded to say that the best of things must have an end, that they all must die some time and go to another world. He then endeavored to describe the abode of the blessed, and exhorted his listeners to so live that they should go there after death. In short the general impression left on the minds of his hearers was that heaven was really a very good place to go to if—if they could not live in Santa Barbara. It is needless to say that the inhabitants of this earthly paradise thought it a remarkably fine sermon.

Among the foothills, about 300 feet above the sea level, stands

THE OLD MISSION

built by the Spanish Padres, one hundred years ago. It is built of adobe and sandstone in the Moorish style of architecture, is painted white, and with its two towers is a land mark for the country around. This Mission is a curious and interesting place. It is still kept up and there are five monks residing there at the present time. The walls are eight feet thick, and are covered on the inside with pictures, some of which were painted in Spain, long before the Mission itself was built. There are also a great many carvings in wood, marvelously well done; these were executed by the Mexican Indians. We made the acquaintance of Padre Francoir, who showed and explained to us the many interesting features of the place. In the vestry room we saw the antique vestments of the Church heavily wrought in gold and silver by the Spanish nuns; huge solid silver candlesticks and golden anchors. Then with great care Father Francoir unlocked a little gold casket, and lying beneath a glass plate was disclosed a bit of a bone formerly belonging to Santa Barbara herself. Away up in the old tower is a chime of bells, not especially musical, but "Like sweet bells jingled, out of tune and barab." They seem to think it necessary to ding them at all hours of the day and night, and they certainly do make a most infernal racket. At a little distance in the rear are the Mission water works, which furnish the city with water. The water is brought from a mountain cañon and is exceedingly hard.

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The amusements prevalent here are, first, horseback riding—every one rides—they use the little broncho ponies and the great Mexican saddles, which almost cover up diminutive steeds. But to see riding, one must see the Mexicans themselves. Imagine a swarthy skinned, black-haired individual in a white sombrero and fiery red necktie, galloping along on a little "calico" horse, with long flapping stirrup leathers, a Mexican bit and bridle, with the lines ending in a lash, which is twirled in the right hand of the rider. How they can ride! Not according to our severe method in the East, but easily and gracefully. It is said they can spread a blanket on the ground, run a horse onto it and turn him there. I have seen them ride along at full speed and pick a hat from the ground. They are like Centaurs. So much for the "Greaser." He can ride and throw the riata. These are his only accomplishments. The town is fast becoming a New England settlement. The Mexicans are being pushed to the wall and very bitter they feel toward the Americans, who are taking possession of their beautiful country.

Another amusement is picnicing on the beach and surf bathing; the water is so warm that one can go in any season of the year. A ride of six miles up into the mountains takes one to the Hot Sulphur Springs, where one can take a bath in different springs in the rocks with the temperature varying from 115 degrees F. to 50 degrees; 115 degrees is fully hot enough, and just about as much as one can stand. These springs are said to be a sure cure for all rheumatic complaints.

A ride of fifteen miles takes one to the big ranches of Hollister, Cooper and Stow. The first two men raise almonds,

English walnut, (which are grown in their perfection here), apricot s, limes, etc. Cooper raises the same variety, but devotes the greater part of attention to olives and to the production of olive oil. He is now producing an immense quantity, and although his price per bottle is 25 cents more than that of the French oil, he cannot begin to supply the market. These ranches were formerly over-run with grasshoppers, which came over from the mesa (table-lands) opposite, in clouds. Now the farmers go over in the breeding season and plow all of the eggs under ground. In this way they avoid the huge swarms.

The farmers here cannot afford to raise vegetables for the market, the Chinese gardeners being their competitors. It is astonishing to see how cheaply they can afford to sell. A family can get all they can use in a day for five cents; for example, one can get two bunches of celery, two quarts of tomatoes, some turnips and a carrot, for the regular sum of five cents. They raise as a general thing six crops a year from a single piece of ground.

In the character of any one who has lived any time in California, cordiality is the first thing noticed; the ability to tell big yarns is the next; (by the way I hope the readers of the *Courant* will not think that I have lived here long enough to be influenced.) Every where the stranger is welcomed and made to feel at home immediately. It is so different here in this respect from cold New England. I suppose it is all due to the climate. In my next letter I hope I may have something interesting to say of a journey on horse-back from Santa Barbara to Los Angeles.

G. F. M.